



Honors Research & Creativity Symposium - Poster Guidelines

Designing a poster can be intimidating if you haven't done it much before. Here are a few tips to help make the process easier, and guide you through a few basic graphic design principles.

Things to note:

- a. Your poster should be created as 24 x 36 (actual size) vector graphic .pdf, or 300 dpi if raster graphic.
- b. Landscape or portrait orientation is acceptable
- c. Your poster will be printed on vinyl
- d. **Please send your poster to honors@rit.edu no later than Monday, Nov. 17th @ 4:30 pm**
- No late submissions will be accepted.
 - i. Please use the subject for your email: Last Name_Symposium Poster (if multiple students provide all last names)
 - ii. If you do not make the deadline, you can still go to the HUB as an individual to have your poster printed but they cannot guarantee it will be ready in time for the Symposium
 - iii. The deadline of 11/17/2024 is to ensure that the HUB has time to print all posters we receive; extensions will not be available
- e. You can use your Honors Enrichment Grant to pay for your poster
 - i. Posters will cost \$44.97
 - ii. Please indicate in your email when sending your file that you'd like to use your grant

You can design your poster on a number of programs. Some common ones include Adobe Illustrator or InDesign, Microsoft PowerPoint, and Google Slides. All of these programs allow you to adjust the size of your presentation/canvas, and set the resolution to 300 dpi. If possible, be sure to set the color preferences to CMYK rather than RGB (this is typical for projects you intend to have printed, rather than displayed digitally).

[Changing the size of a Google Slide](#)

[Changing a presentation size in powerpoint](#)

[Resizing the canvas in Adobe Illustrator](#)

[Resizing the page in Adobe Indesign](#)

What should be included on your poster?

The presentation goals of your poster are dependent on your topic. The goal of a poster presentation is to make your voice heard. The poster should complement your discussion but it is not a replacement for verbal communication. Use this checklist as a guide for what needs to be included on your poster:

- ☐ Short title, properly capitalized (first impressions are important 😊)
- ☐ Your name
- ☐ Brief Introduction to your project
- ☐ Brief background information if necessary
- ☐ Any relevant pictures, diagrams, charts or figures (this may include a diagram of your process) with captions
- ☐ Summary of any conclusions/takeaways found
- ☐ References

**If you'd like to utilize the checkbox feature, make a copy of this document on your drive!*

You will stand beside your poster and have the opportunity to elaborate on your project as a whole in discussion. Think about this when writing the summative content of your poster and consider how the material on the poster will help you communicate your work.

How do you plan a layout/visual flow?

Think of your poster as a visual story that flows through your process, starting with an introduction in the upper left that prepares your reader for the main part of your project. The “middle” of your poster should hold the body, or explanation, of your experience.

Remember that you'll be talking alongside your poster, so this is a great opportunity to utilize charts/diagrams to help who you're talking to visualize your experience.

The end of your story should drive home why your project is interesting and the key information that someone should take away when they walk away from your poster.

What if I'm not sure how to layout my poster to help tell a story?

Try drawing out your layout ideas before getting started online! Consider sketching out sections of your poster on a piece of paper or write down each section/figure you want to include on a sticky note and try moving the notes around. **Ask a friend or classmate to take a look before you move forward.**

Keep your title and name across the top of your poster, as this is where we tend to look first for overview information. The rest of your poster is more subjective based on the kind of project you are presenting. Western audiences read from left to right, top to bottom. Large posters should follow this format so they aren't confusing to readers passing by, but at the same time should avoid having super wide, thin sections of text spanning the entire page. Some examples are shown below.

This is an example project title

Firstname Lastname

Subheading A

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut velit blanditis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quas soluta sit reiciendis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia porro quo nuncquam voluptatum ut dolorum praesentium.

At modi noster qui accusantium sunt hic blanditis voluptatem in consectetur iusto aut repudiandae incidunt. Rem quae corrupti aut dolores magnam ab ratione paratur ut eius doloribus ab error labore aut quibusdam aliquis. Sit quam quibusdam ut galisum aperiam et tempore aliquid cum repudiandae velit qui placeat fuga ut earum nihil.

Subheading B

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut velit blanditis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quas soluta sit reiciendis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia porro quo nuncquam voluptatum ut dolorum praesentium. At modi noster qui accusantium sunt hic blanditis voluptatem in consectetur iusto aut repudiandae.

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Figure A

Subheading C

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut velit blanditis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quas soluta sit reiciendis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia porro quo nuncquam voluptatum ut dolorum praesentium.

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This example shows why you should avoid wide, thin text boxes. They can be hard to read, and limit the amount of content you can include on your poster. They also tend to make it difficult to share multiple figures/images.

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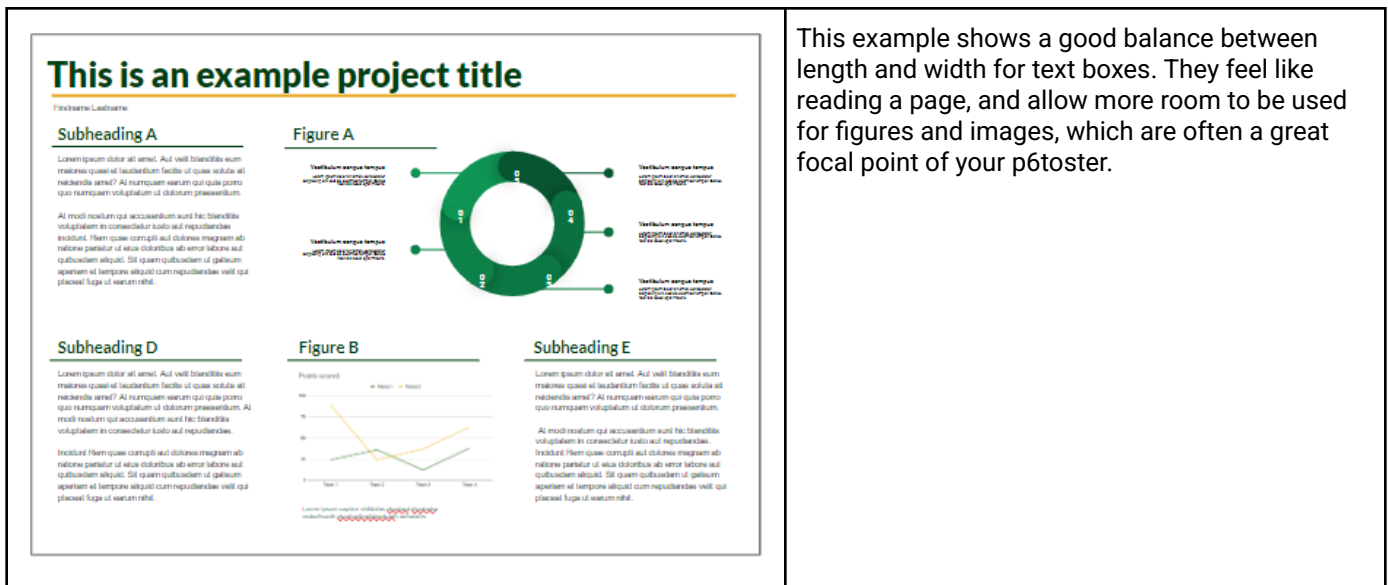
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Figure B

Figure A

This example shows the opposite effect: each section isn't so wide, but is instead tall and skinny. Being so tall, you may not be able to include a second "row" of information, although this is still better than the wide and thin. Making sure there are 40-70 characters per line (or 7-12 words) is a good rule of thumb to make sure your readers' eyes won't be strained.



When you actually move onto the digital landscape to create your poster, consider using **guides** to make organizing your poster easier. These are thin lines that go away when your poster is printed, which make it easier to snap text or sections into alignment or even sections.

[Using guides in Google Slides](#)

[Using Guides in PowerPoint](#)

[Using Guides in Adobe Illustrator](#)

[Using Guides in Adobe Indesign](#)

Typefaces, text size, and alignment

Here are a few tips to help make your text clean and easy to read.

Typefaces

- Use a **maximum of 2 typefaces** on one poster
- Generally, sans serif fonts are easier to read from a distance, which is what your audience will be doing. Some examples of strong sans serif fonts include Arial, Helvetica, Open Sans, Futura, Lato, and Verdana.
- Generally, left alignment is the way to go for any text you want your viewer to be able to easily read. Having all of the lines of text along the left side of the page makes it easy for your eye to scan to the next row: there's a reason books are printed with left-alignment.
- Having variable size and type treatment (bold, italics) is important for establishing hierarchy. Hierarchy makes text easier to read, improves organization, and draws attention to the main points of a poster.

- The body copy of your poster should be around 24 pt font. Although this does seem large, this ensures that a reader can view your poster from a couple feet away. Section headings should be slightly larger and the poster title should be larger than the headings.
- Captioning and references can be a smaller font, as this typically holds content a reader will only consider if they are also researching a similar topic. 12-16 pt font is appropriate.
- Consider defining a typeface guide to use throughout your entire poster in order to establish clear hierarchy and keep a sense of consistency. Here are some examples:

This example includes just 1 typeface, with three different applications to create hierarchy. All typefaces are left-aligned. All of these lines are Arial: The title is 60 pt, bold The section headings are 36 pt, bold The body copy is 24 pt, regular Captioning is 12 pt, regular	Poster title Section headings Body copy - Lorem ipsum Captioning, References
This example includes just 1 typeface, with three different applications to create hierarchy. All typefaces are left-aligned. All of these lines are Lato: The title is 60 pt, black The section headings are 30 pt, black The body copy is 24 pt, regular Captioning is 12 pt, regular	Poster title Section headings Body copy - Lorem ipsum Captioning, References
This example includes 2 typefaces, with three different applications to create hierarchy. All typefaces are left-aligned. The title is Merriweather 60 pt, black The section headings are Open Sans 30 pt, bold The body copy is Open Sans 24 pt, regular Captioning is Open Sans 12 pt, regular	Poster title Section headings Body copy - Lorem ipsum Captioning, References

Colors, contrast, and legibility

Simplicity is key. Using 2-3 colors will give your poster a clean, easy to understand look while also drawing attention.

Some tips:

- Solid colors (as opposed to gradients) are easier to make look professional.
- Light and dark color pairings are often a good choice. Colors that are too bright can sometimes be hard to read. Consider using a tone (color that is not pure hue, pastel, or shade) if you'd like to use a fun color.
- Use color contrast checkers to make sure that your colors are legible. You can find one [here](#) or by googling "Color contrast checker". This ensures that your colors are easy to look at, and are more accessible.

Below are some examples of the concepts mentioned above.

This is an example project title

Firstname Lastname

Introduction

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis, nam maiores quae et laudantium facilis ut quam soluta ut recordis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia peris qui nuncquam volutatum ut dolorem praesentium solute.

At modi nostrum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis voluptatem in consectetur laute aut repudiandae ut eius doloribus ab error labore aut.

Figure A: Methods and Process

2000 2001 2002 2003 2004 2005

Background

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis, nam maiores quae et laudantium facilis ut quam soluta ut recordis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia peris qui nuncquam volutatum ut dolorem praesentium. At modi nostrum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis voluptatem in consectetur laute aut repudiandae.

Includere Rem quae congeit aut dolorem magnam ab eorum paratur ut eius doloribus ab error labore aut quibusdam aliquat. Sit quam quibusdam ut gallium aperiam et tempore aliquat cum repudiandae veli qui placeat fuga ut earum nihil. Sit quam quibusdam ut gallium aperiam et tempore aliquat.

Analysis and Conclusions

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis, nam maiores quae et laudantium facilis ut quam soluta ut recordis amet? At nuncquam earum qui quia peris qui nuncquam volutatum ut dolorem praesentium. At modi nostrum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis voluptatem in consectetur laute aut repudiandae.

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45%

45% increase in productivity

28%

28% decrease in error rate

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The first one is an example of a project that used just one accent color. Note that this helps keep the entire thing cohesive easily, and the color is easy to read/provides strong contrast.

The second, however, has a lighter color and less contrast used in the title. This makes the title harder to read, and should be avoided. A Color Checker test showed that this color against white had a contrast rating of 1.55, which is way below the recommended contrast score of 3 for large text (like a title).

This is an example project title

F. Bismarck, L. Bismarck

Subheading A

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quae soluta sit recitanda amet? At nuncupam veniam qui quia porro qui nuncupam volupatum ut doctum praesentium. At mod nolum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis volupatem in consectetur lauto aut repudiandae Incidunt. Item quae conipit aut dolores magnam ab ratione paratur ut eius distributa ab enim labore aut quibusdam aliquot. Sit quem quibusdam ut gelium aperiam et tempore aliquot cum repudiandae veli qui placeat fuga ut veniam nihil.

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Figure A



Subheading D

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quae soluta sit recitanda amet? At nuncupam veniam qui quia porro qui nuncupam volupatum ut doctum praesentium. At mod nolum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis volupatem in consectetur lauto aut repudiandae Incidunt. Item quae conipit aut dolores magnam ab ratione paratur ut eius distributa ab enim labore aut quibusdam aliquot. Sit quem quibusdam ut gelium aperiam et tempore aliquot cum repudiandae veli qui placeat fuga ut veniam nihil.

Figure B



Subheading E

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. Aut veli blanditiis eum maiores quasi et laudantium facilis ut quae soluta sit recitanda amet? At nuncupam veniam qui quia porro qui nuncupam volupatum ut doctum praesentium. At mod nolum qui accusantium sunt hic blanditiis volupatem in consectetur lauto aut repudiandae Incidunt. Item quae conipit aut dolores magnam ab ratione paratur ut eius distributa ab enim labore aut quibusdam aliquot. Sit quem quibusdam ut gelium aperiam et tempore aliquot cum repudiandae veli qui placeat fuga ut veniam nihil.

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This first one is an example of a project that uses two colors that are very predominant while maintaining legibility. The yellow is used only for accents/borders, since it is less legible to read, and the medium blue is used for large and medium text.

The second example shows two things:

- First, how the brightness of this blue can be straining on the eyes, and should be adjusted.
- Second, the lightness of the yellow again has low contrast - which is less important here where it's used as a background color, but should be avoided in any charts or diagrams. Its color contrast rating against white came out to 1.21, which is much lower than the recommended 4.5.

This is an example project title

F. Bismarck, L. Bismarck

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The example on the left uses color, but still feels very “clean” and has a lot of white space. Headings, diagrams, and titles use a very dark color green to add a hint of color.

The example on the right shows a similar concept, but using a color that is too bright/not muted at all. It's straining on the eyes and feels unprofessional.

Preparing for printing

[Exporting PDF from Powerpoint](#): Note, set DPI when at the “Options” menu step

[Exporting PDF from Google Slides](#): Note, slides do not allow you to set DPI manually in their program. Any text will automatically export at 300 DPI, but in order to have any images you include also export at high resolution, they need to be high resolution when you import them to your slides. Charts/Graphs created in Google Suite and linked will also maintain high resolution.

[Export PDF from Adobe Illustrator](#) Note, DPI and CMYK set when the document was created.

[Export PDF from Adobe Indesign](#) Note, DPI and CMYK set when the document was created.

Before exporting for print, check these things:

- ☐ 300 dpi
 - ☐ CMYK print settings
 - ☐ Size of poster is 42” wide x 30” tall (landscape orientation)
 - ☐ Have a friend check it again
 - ☐ Spellcheck, punctuation, grammar
-